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Legibility, Sacrament and Glitch in “The Whale”

Abstract

This collection of short essays is based on my degree project titled “The Whale.” The Whale is a poetic multimedia work that deals in prose that is deliberately opaque and protective of its own words. The work consists of a ten foot triptych of embroidered poetry with video projected through the front, as well as a performance of labor and devotion. The final installation serves as a letter and a shrine, a place of infinity, contemplation, and a sea of language. Something to swim through, something that envelops you, something to exist alongside rather than interpret. Prose washes over you through layers of artifactual colors, degraded and unrecognizable images. The poetry tells the abstracted story of a queer relationship suffering from a fracture that warps and divides time into “before” and “after,” and the act of embroidery serves to physically stitch time back into something continuous. The Whale explores the amount of physical and emotional distance between a reader and the text, dealing with varying degrees of access through the comprehension of the text as well as the physical obscuring of it through color, materiality and light. The installation is an intangible queer body itself and an ode to queer bodies and relationship structures, reclaiming them as sacred through secular frameworks, purging pain into a textile of catharsis. The work is highly specific with intentional withholdings, where meaning is found through absence, implication, excess and gesture. The Whale explores what it means to read and “be read,” and what it means to write as a ritual of devotion to being legible, with fabric as skin and words as permanent marks on a formless body.

The Whale is a triptych, so I'm structuring this collection of essays as a triptych as well. The first essay on legibility talks mostly about the physical and formal qualities of the work, the way it exists in space and why. The second essay on sacrament speaks on the conceptual and religious aspects of the work, as well as the qualities of the prose. Finally, the third essay on glitch talks about the video aspect of the installation.

The “Text” in Textile: Legibility, Transsexuality and Monstruosity

*“I am the little girl who walks through a village in Cantabria, climbs cherry trees and scratches her legs. I am the boy who sleeps in the byre with the cows. I am the cow climbing the mountain slopes that hides from human eyes. I am Frankenstein’s monster, carrying a flower and searching for someone to love while all around flee. **I am the reader whose body becomes a book.** I am the teenage boy kissing a girl behind the church door. I am the young girl who dresses up as a Jesuit and learns screeds of Spinoza’s Ethics by heart. I am the skinhead lesbian going to seminars on BDSM at the Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender Community Center on West 13th Street in Manhattan. I am the person who refuses to identify as a woman and who self-administers small doses of testosterone every day.”*

I am opening this short essay with a quote from Paul Preciado’s “Can The Monster Speak?” a 2019 lecture at a psychoanalysis conference in France. Similarly to Preciado, I find myself in a fluid, transgender body that has shaped my artistic practice through my constructed, embodied experience that refuses the idea of Cartesian dualism. My degree project, *The Whale*, exists as a testament to that. The idea for *The Whale* first came to me upon hearing the words “a body of text.” I became haunted with this idea, what does it mean for text to have a body? What does it mean for text to *be* transsexual? To be stitched together from language, in a state of excess and abundance, designed and crafted from scratch by its owner? To be modified, scarred, seam ripped, surgically altered. I am interested in the idea of this transsexual body of text with degrees of legibility, the way an identity cannot be contained and defined despite its explicit, written nature. To transition as a way to make yourself legible, to devote yourself to language as a means of externalizing your insides.

The first keyword I'm defining in this collection of short essays will be legibility. When I talk about legibility in *The Whale*, I am referring to it in two senses. Legibility as in, how hard or easy something is to physically read. This includes formal qualities such as the size of the text, the clarity of the font or handwriting and the atmospheric conditions which would make it easier or harder to read, such as light or darkness. On the other hand, I am also referring to a metaphysical legibility. This includes how easy a text is to comprehend and the extent of the abstraction of narrative ideas as well as the legibility of images and bodies and how they are described through words.

The trans body has long been explored through the lens of monstrosity and the other. Something alien, something terrifying in its resistance to categorization. In *The Whale*, I am dealing with the idea of a monstrous, trans body as a body of text. This text can only be described through its own words, it cannot be broken down, it cannot be quoted because it is not individual sentences but a living archive of trans memory. It cannot be assigned meaning or definition, for it is already assigning meaning to itself. It is completely visible and legible, yet its size, its abundance, is imposing.

"My Word To Victor Frankenstein" is an essay and performance piece by Susan Stryker that has been following me throughout my literary and artistic career. Stryker describes the trans body as follows: "The transsexual body is an unnatural body. It is the product of medical science. It is a technological construction. It is flesh torn apart and sewn together again in a shape other than that in which it was born." Prose in my project takes this same shape, a literary construction of a transgender body making itself legible in space.

"We use "body" to give material form to an idea that has no form, an assemblage that is abstract." (Legacy Russell, *Glitch Feminism*)

A Chapel In The Hospital: Queer Prose and Sacrament

*Actually, you said Love, for you,
is larger than the usual romantic love. It's like a religion. It's
terrifying. No one
will ever want to sleep with you.*

Richard Siken, "Litany in Which Certain Things Are Crossed Out"

I was eleven years old when I first listened to the album "Infinity on High" by Fall Out Boy. For the last decade, I have been obsessed with Pete Wentz' lyricism, his poetry, his blog posts. There was one lyric that captured my teenage attention and has been etched into my consciousness so deeply that I got it tattooed on my body. The lyric, from "Hum Hallelujah," goes as follows: "I love you in the same way there's a chapel in a hospital." There was something about the lyric that struck a deep chord in me even though I struggled to even explain out loud what the words mean. It's that exact feeling that I chase with my writing and my degree project. Words that you feel in your bones, sentiments that you understand intuitively, a sentence you feel so strongly about that you pay a beautiful butch trans woman to needle it with ink into your skin in her attic studio, with thick bold lines taking up much of your thigh. In between the words, my artist drew a simple, shaky drawing of a chapel on fire, black smoke pouring out of its windows. I can still see the tremble in her hand when I look at my skin. Shaky, permanent, queer lines that will be on my skin until I die.

"I love you in the same way there's a chapel in the hospital." I still have a hard time explaining why this means so much to me and what it spells out in the greater context of my degree project. What does it mean to love someone the same way there's a chapel in the hospital? To me this spells desperation, a last resort, when the only thing left to do is pray regardless of if you believe in a god or not, when love is doomed despite pleading to the sky.

I have long been exploring this connection between love, especially queer and T4T* love, that so often feels doomed the second it begins, with the divine. The sacred feeling of continuity that can be achieved only through T4T relationships, and how fleeting and temporary those can be. The word I will be defining in this short essay is “sacrament” where I am proposing the queer body as a divine subject and my degree project “The Whale” as a shrine, a place of worship, a setting for queer sacrament. The Whale is where I express my religious devotion to queerness and transsexuality, upholding them as an innate, divine part of my human experience. I use terms like “religion,” “divinity” and “sacrament” in a secular way, but I am referring broadly to the idea of the divine as an idea of continuity, the sense that we exist in a world that is greater than any single one of us, that we are discontinuous beings seeking to belong in a continuous world (Bataille). Sacrament in this short essay is catch-all term for experiences or feelings that cannot be explained through non-secular religion or science. Divinity in The Whale becomes a literary undertaking and its installation is similar to the construction of a cathedral or church, a sacred place.

Through this research into queerness and divinity, I came across trans scholar T. Fleischman and fell deeply in love with their book “Syzygy, Beauty: An Essay,” an experimental work that tells the story of a polyamorous T4T relationship through abstracted prose poetry. The concept of syzygy symbolizes the narrator, the narrator’s partner, and the narrator’s partner’s partner as an alignment of celestial bodies with gravity, orbits and tensions placing them at distances from each other. I was most interested in the sacred aspect of this tension, how these queer bodies interact with each other on a broad scale, across a vast cosmos. The prose is similarly stylistically to my own, deliberately opaque, written like an intimate letter that only a few people in the world can truly understand, gaining universality through specificity rather than generalization.

In The Whale, I deal with non-standard relationships in a similar way. Two subjects are described as planets, orbiting around each other, the narrator as an asteroid crashing the orbit,

messing with the delicate balance, throwing the cosmos into chaos. The cosmos gains richness when considering each of these planets as transsexual subjects, each planet as sacred, fluid, mutable, coming together into a broader, messy system that just somehow *works* until it doesn't.

T4T Glitch: Queerness and The Poor Image

“The poor image is a copy in motion. Its quality is bad, its resolution substandard. As it accelerates, it deteriorates. It is a ghost of an image, a preview, a thumbnail, an errant idea, an itinerant image distributed for free, squeezed through slow digital connections, compressed, reproduced, ripped, remixed, as well as copied and pasted into other channels of distribution.” – Hito Steyerl

Ever since I started dabbling in video, I have been interested in the poor image. The quality of an image can add so much richness and context to its existence. The value of datamoshing for me lies in its specificity. When an image is degraded, the degradation speaks as loudly as the subject itself. I never gravitated toward crystal clear, high resolution images that reveal everything there is to know. I like to obscure details behind static noise, identities hidden in blurred pixels and laggy footage that skips over important moments.

This fluidity in the image, its mutable form, the video as an assemblage of different colored pixels reminds me of queerness. The truth isn't in what you see, but what is hidden by what you see. “The condition of the images speaks not only of countless transfers and reformattings, but also of the countless people who cared enough about them to convert them over and over again, to add subtitles, reedit, or upload them.” (Steyerl)

I like to think of video and in turn my body as a poor image. My body is shaped by the queer people around me, they all take part in reformatting me, sharing me, restructuring me. In T4T relationships, this multiplicity becomes more obvious. My partner is every queer person before them, and so am I. Meaning this image is barely legible, if anything can be distinguished at all. The resolution is low, the colors are bright, oversaturated, artifacted, the video skips frames and pixels travel across the screen like bubbles across water. After iterating with the videos for hours until the image is sufficiently fried, sufficiently illegible and abstract and

indistinguishable, I run the video through a data moshing algorithm one last time to make sure everything is sufficiently encrypted. The video becomes deliberately opaque, fighting against its own interpretation, the image is so decayed it becomes encompassing of the original image and its journey into abstraction, it tells a story of the image and then everything that happened after. When I started to work on my degree project, I remember deliberately lowering the resolution on one of my data moshing experiments in order to hide my tattoos. It's important details like that that hide behind the noise.

In *The Whale*, I treat video in a similar way. I layer videos on top of each other and blend them together, I mess with the colors to abstract the image, I create silhouettes out of shadows, I make them bright pink, and I use them to hide the truth. Legacy Russell explains my attitude towards the glitch well in *Glitch Feminism*: "Glitch is all about traversing along edges and stepping to the limits, those we occupy and push through, on our journey to defining ourselves. Glitch is also about claiming our right to complexity, to range, within and beyond the proverbial margins." Video in *The Whale* serves to counteract the directness of the text, highlighting two opposite ends of abstraction. Video, like the narrator of the prose, is unreliable.

"Mimetism is a poor tool when thinking about gender transition since it still relies on binary logic. To be this or that, to be one thing and imitate something else. Either you are a man, or you are a woman. A trans person is not imitating anything, just as a crocodile is not imitating a floating tree trunk, or a chameleon the colours of the world. To be trans is to cease to be a crocodile and connect with one's vegetal future, to understand that the rainbow can become a skin." (Paul Preciado, *Can The Monster Speak?*)

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